

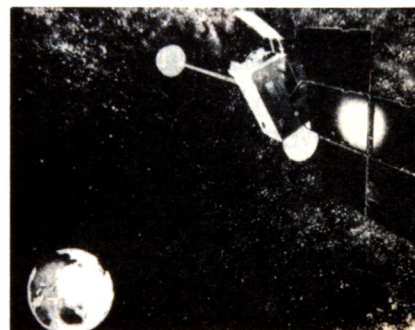
1982 COLOUR TELEVISION IS INTRODUCED

Out of the Dark Ages

With the import of 50,000 colour sets, Indian TV takes its first big step

The year was 1982. India was gearing up for the Asian Games, a colourful spectacle. But most of the country was in the danger of seeing it in shades of black and white. Until a Union Cabinet decision changed the way people saw television forever. In the beginning, it was a temporary permit, with the Union Government allowing the import of 50,000 colour television sets by November of that year. But by the end of it, the Indian viewer was ready to spend Rs 8,000 on an Indian set and up to Rs 15,000 on the imported version. The government raked in the money, earning Rs 70 crore in customs revenue from imported sets, with one lakh sets imported into the country. In December 1982, *INDIA TODAY* reported a virtual craze in Hong Kong, Singapore and Dubai where shops were practically emptied of television sets for Indian use, even as recipients of the sets in India willingly paid the concessional 190 per cent customs duty. I&B Minister Vasant Sathe's brainchild, it opened the doors to expanding the television market in a big way, organising it and bringing in the bigger players. It was television's hardware revolution. As Bhaskar Ghose, former director general of Doordarshan told *INDIA TODAY* in 1999, "Colour was just a metaphor for a switchover to high technology." It was followed by Doordarshan's networking phase. In 1982, television transmitters jumped from 35 to 100, by 1990, the figure was getting ready to cross the 400 mark. Critics called it India's taste for modern consumerism, a hand-maiden of the commercial film industry. But for the Indian consumer, it was much more than that. It was an opportunity to see the world in all colour.

by Chitra Subramanyam



AN ARTIST'S CONCEPT OF INSAT-1A

THE MAIN EVENT

INSAT-1A is Launched

For all its pioneering role, INSAT-1A is a satellite that the Space Department may want to quickly forget. Almost the only thing that can be claimed on its behalf is that it is operational: certainly a triumph in itself, but one robbed of much of its real value. The launch was late by 22 months. Despite that leeway, most of the related ground facilities to make use of the satellite are not in position. By the time they are, the satellite will probably have lived out its life, reduced from the planned seven years to perhaps just three because of the unanticipated burning up of vital hydrazine fuel. Even before its launch, some fuel had to be off-loaded from the satellite since its weight exceeded the stipulated 1,150 kg.

India Today, May 15, 1982

ALSO

- The Ninth Asian Games are held in Delhi
- NABARD is established to promote sustainable and equitable growth in agriculture
- N.T. Rama Rao wins the Andhra Pradesh elections



THE EVENT MARKED TELEVISION'S HARDWARE REVOLUTION

Petrol Pump Scam

Kickbacks meant 297 outlets allotted by the NDA were cancelled by the apex court in 2002.

Kavya Vishwanathan

Was branded a literary fraud for her book *How Opal Mehta Got Kissed, Got Wild, and Got a Life*.

Cash for Questions A

2005 sting operation showed ministers accepting cash to ask questions in Parliament.

Satyam Fraud Pegged

at Rs 14,000 crore, the fraud shook up corporate India last year.

Madhu Koda Scam The

former Jharkhand CM's money laundering ventures worth Rs 4,000 crore are being probed.